CHAPTER I

Before She Had a Name

Kolkata · 7 March 2023

“Imagine passing a thousand strangers in a lifetime, never knowing that among them walks someone whose absence you will one day recognise more readily than the presence of everyone else. Perhaps that is the strangest thing about human encounters: we are never told which ordinary moment we shall spend the rest of our lives remembering.”

Outside the classroom windows, Kolkata had already given itself over to the morning. Horns interrupted one another in the street; inside, a chair scraped across the floor, and someone at the back laughed. The coaching session had begun barely a week earlier. Students still asked one another which chapters had been covered, borrowed pens with a little hesitation, and sat beside people whose faces they recognised before they knew their names.

Utkarsh occupied the first row of the right-hand column, beside Basavi. Her company made those unfamiliar mornings easier. There was someone to speak to before the lesson, someone with whom he could exchange a glance when the waiting grew tedious. His notebook lay open before him. He had come expecting another morning of Arithmetic.

Then the door opened.

The young woman paused at the entrance, looking across the occupied benches for a place to sit. Utkarsh happened to be facing the doorway. His gaze stayed there.

He found her beautiful. The thought came so readily that he felt no need to qualify it, although he was suddenly aware of how long he had been looking. She moved her attention from one row to the

next, concerned with finding a seat. Around him, the conversations continued. For a few seconds, he had nothing to contribute to any of them.

Leaning towards Basavi, he lowered his voice.

“Look at that gorgeous girl.”

Basavi followed his gaze. When she turned back, her amusement was immediate.

“Then go and propose to her, Utkarsh.”

He smiled and shook his head.

“No.”

Basavi returned her attention to the room, still amused. Admitting his admiration aloud had made it rather more difficult to look again. He did anyway, briefly.

The girl had found a place on the bench immediately behind him.

As she approached, Utkarsh turned to the front. He heard her belongings settle on the table, then the small sounds of someone making room for herself. A few feet separated them now. He looked down at the notebook he had opened before she arrived and resisted the temptation to turn around merely to confirm what he already knew.

From beside him, Basavi resumed their conversation. He answered, a little late.

The faculty member had yet to arrive. After a while, the young woman spoke to Basavi, her question carrying across the narrow space between the benches.

“How many chapters have been completed so far?”

Utkarsh turned before Basavi could reply.

“Nothing much, actually. We’ve only been doing the basics of Arithmetic. None of the major chapters has started yet.”

She acknowledged his answer, satisfied that joining a little later had not left her far behind. That was the whole exchange. He turned back towards the front.

Only then did it occur to him that she had asked Basavi.

Had he answered too quickly? He could hardly withdraw an explanation about Arithmetic, and there had been nothing improper about offering it. Still, he found himself considering the few words he had spoken with an attention he rarely gave to an answer about the syllabus. He hoped he had sounded helpful. He also hoped Basavi had not noticed how promptly he had become so.

When the faculty member arrived, notebooks opened along the rows and the room settled. Utkarsh followed the examples, made his notes, and returned to the work before him. Once or twice, he became aware of the girl sitting behind him. He had no reason to turn, so he remained facing the board.

By the end of the lesson, he had spoken to her without introducing himself. He knew neither her name nor what she had made of his interruption. The answer he had given was correct. For the moment, that would have to be enough.

In the days that followed, the classroom acquired its own small arrangements. Students settled into preferred seats. Borrowed notes became reasons to talk, and conversations begun before a lesson were picked up again afterwards. Utkarsh continued sitting with Basavi. The young woman moved elsewhere, usually joining a group of five or six students whose company seemed easy to her.

He began recognising where she sat without making a deliberate search of the room. Sometimes he mentioned her to Basavi, who needed little reminding of the morning at the doorway. Her amusement made him smile, although it also left him more careful about how often he brought the girl into their conversations.

He had found other people attractive before. What stayed with him this time was the wish for another exchange, something slightly longer than a question about the lessons. He could imagine asking her a perfectly ordinary question. Finding a moment in which to do it seemed, somehow, less ordinary.

Later in March, he and Basavi lingered beneath a tree outside the coaching centre after class. They were discussing the following

day's lesson when she turned her head and he noticed a faint trace of vermilion along the parting of her hair.

He hesitated.

"Basavi, are you married?"

"Yes."

He looked at her for a moment, surprised by how much a simple answer could reveal about someone he had already begun to think of as familiar.

They had spent several mornings together. He knew how easily she could tease him, the place she usually occupied, the sound of her voice beside him. Beyond the coaching centre, though, there was a life about which he had scarcely asked. He had mistaken the comfort of knowing her in one place for knowing her more fully.

He accepted her answer without pressing for details. Their conversation returned to the class, and when they parted, he expected to see her again as usual.

Her attendance grew irregular. When he asked whether she would come the following morning, she often replied, "Not tomorrow," or something equally brief. He did not insist on an explanation. They continued speaking on WhatsApp, and he sent her notes from the lessons she missed.

At first, he still looked towards the door when the room was filling, expecting her to appear. Then he began putting his belongings down without leaving quite so much space beside them. He could message her later. Nevertheless, the beginning of a class felt different when there was no familiar voice to fill the waiting.

Basavi had never announced that she was leaving. Each absence belonged to a particular morning; he had no reason to gather them into a farewell. Yet the classroom was changing around the empty place, and he was changing his place within it.

He gradually spent more time with the group the young woman usually joined. His interest in her helped him overcome his initial reserve, but the conversations soon offered pleasures of their own. He listened, contributed when he had something to say, and found it

easier to join them the next morning. The girl was still someone he barely knew. Being near her had not immediately made speaking to her easier.

During one of these conversations, someone suggested an outing after class. They ought to spend an afternoon somewhere other than the coaching centre. Utkarsh encouraged the idea. A WhatsApp group was created, restaurants were proposed, and they agreed to leave after their second class finished at two.

The outing was arranged for the twenty-second of March.

Utkarsh read the discussion as suggestions appeared and arrangements changed. He wanted to go. He also wanted to know whether she would be there.

Other people responded; she remained silent. When a new message appeared, he checked who had sent it before reading what it said. Afterwards, he sometimes scrolled through the conversation again, although nothing in it had changed. He could have asked whether she intended to join them. A practical question, addressed to another student. He considered it often enough to recognise how little courage the question itself required, and still left it unasked.

Her silence gave him nothing to work with. Perhaps she was undecided. Perhaps she had other plans. He knew too little about her to distinguish between the possibilities, so he kept them all.

On the twenty-second, the others began gathering their belongings as soon as the afternoon lesson ended. Outside, they talked about the restaurant and what they might order. Utkarsh looked among them for her.

She was not there.

As more students emerged, he glanced towards the entrance again. He tried to do it casually, while someone beside him was speaking. Each time the doorway cleared, he could see a little farther into the premises; each time, she was still absent.

The group began to move. He went with them, then looked back once more at the coaching centre.

He could not explain his disappointment without admitting what he had hoped for. She had never said she would come. He had taken the possibility of her presence and quietly made room for it in the afternoon, imagining a conversation he had not even managed to begin in class.

At the restaurant, he enjoyed himself. The talk wandered, someone made a joke, and he laughed with the others. As the afternoon went on, he stopped listening for an arrival. These were people whose company he was beginning to value, and he was glad he had come.

Only when they parted did he think of her again. During the meal, there had been no need to explain his interest or conceal it; there had been enough happening to occupy him. Now, on the way home, he could admit that he had hoped to speak to her. He regretted, a little, how much easier it had been to wait for the outing than to ask her a question himself.

Afterwards, Utkarsh began staying at the coaching centre more often when the afternoon class ended. There was a library attached to the premises, although by two o'clock its open books frequently served as a backdrop to conversations. Students exchanged jokes, complained about difficult questions, and delayed the journey home. He grew comfortable among those who regularly stayed.

On some afternoons, he hoped the girl might stay too.

She never did. She left with the departing students, and he turned towards the library. Inside, someone would make space for him or draw him into a conversation already under way, and the afternoon would acquire another reason to be there.

Occasionally, footsteps near the entrance made him look up. When they belonged to someone else, he returned to the discussion. He began to recognise this small movement of expectation in himself: the glance, the brief pause, the effort to pick up the sentence he had stopped following. It embarrassed him more than he would have liked to admit. He wondered how long he could go on wanting an opportunity while doing so little to create one.

Among the people he came to know better were Tanisha and Nikita, both a little older than him. Their easy manner helped him settle into the company. With them, he could listen without worrying about appearing too quiet and speak without rehearsing the remark beforehand. Increasingly, he stayed because he wanted another hour with his friends.

One afternoon, sitting with the two of them in the library, he found himself approaching the question he had postponed for weeks.

"Tanisha, who's that girl who usually sits with you?"

Tanisha turned towards him, her expression brightening.

"Which girl?"

"You know," he said. "The one who sits with your group."

Even as he spoke, he heard how little he had clarified. The question had seemed straightforward until he had to ask it aloud. Now he wanted Tanisha to understand him without requiring him to describe how readily he could pick the girl out of a room.

"Oh." Tanisha exchanged a glance with Nikita. "You want to know?"

Utkarsh looked down briefly. A smile had already escaped him.

"What's so funny?"

"Nothing," Tanisha replied, sounding thoroughly amused. "But listen, Utkarsh. She's a really good girl. As far as I know, she's never been in a relationship, and I don't think she's seeing anyone now either."

Nikita smiled. Utkarsh had expected a name. Tanisha was giving him information for which he had not quite dared to ask, and he was suddenly unsure where to look while receiving it.

"So," she continued, "if you like her, you can try proposing to her."

Propose. Basavi had used the same word on that first morning. It still seemed an extraordinary distance to leap from the few sentences he had exchanged with the girl. He could barely bring

himself to ask about her, and his friends were already encouraging a declaration.

He smiled again. Tanisha let him take his time.

“And her name?” he asked at last.

“Sanondita.”

He repeated it silently, making certain he had heard it correctly.

Sanondita.

The conversation moved on. Utkarsh remained with Tanisha and Nikita, listening, answering when they spoke to him. Once, he realised he had missed part of what was being said. Her name had returned to his thoughts, and with it the girl at the classroom door, looking for somewhere to sit.

When he left, Kolkata was still busy beyond the coaching centre. People passed him on their way home. He had no idea where Sanondita went after class, what occupied her afternoons, or whether she remembered their brief exchange that first morning. She might know him only as someone who sat near the front and had once explained that they were still doing the basics of Arithmetic.

The thought made him smile, then left him a little more conscious of how much remained to be learned.

He could have asked her name himself. Next time, he thought, perhaps he would ask her something else. He tried to imagine turning towards her without waiting for Basavi, or Tanisha, or an outing to make it easier.

Walking home, he found himself quietly trying the name once more, as though preparing to say it to her.